



Advanced Timeline

While animating objects as described in the previous tip, you should use the Advanced Timeline option. Just right-click in the Custom Animation pane and select Show Advanced Timeline. Here you will get little orange boxes on the timeline that indicate the animation event and how long it takes. You can resize these boxes (prolong or shorten the animation) or move them about (fine tune the event orders). When making a presentation, sometimes the animation sequences that PowerPoint provides seem a little to scripted and artificial. It's advisable to use this Advanced Timeline to edit and change things a bit to bring a little "reality" into the animations. Like when causing an Organization Chart to fly-in, instead of having it all fly in one by one, or fly-in one branch at a time, sometimes a little haphazardness to the motion and sequence works better.



Effect Options

From the same Custom Animation pane, right-clicking and selecting Effect Options will bring up a dialog box that will let you tweak effect settings. Here you can add sounds to events and effects and modify the behaviour of an object after the animation completes, such as having it disappear automatically or on the next click, etc. you can also assign the effect to be executed by clicking on another item in the slide.



Resize Proportionately

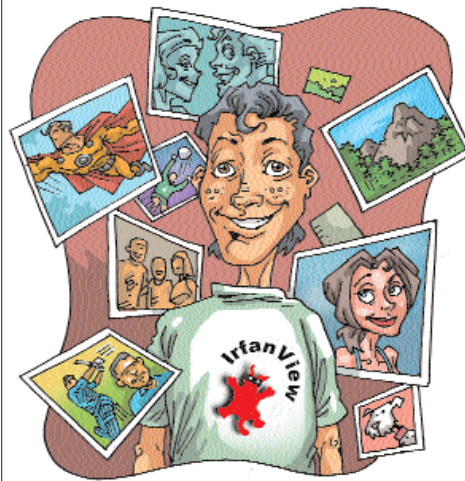
When you want to resize items in a slide, instead of doing so individually, and ruining the aspect ratios in respect to one another, you can just select multiple objects by [Shift]-clicking on them to select them and then resizing using your mouse to drag the corners. Remember to keep [Shift] pressed in order to make sure that individual aspect ratios are maintained. This works with both text and pictures or any other content selected, so just select and resize without worry!



Viewing Sizes

This tip applies throughout Office 2007, and is with regards to the Zoom feature. Most of us use [Ctrl] + mouse scroll down/up to zoom in or out. However, this does so in increments of 10 per cent. For obsessive compulsive people like those of us here at Digit, we often find our documents zooming to just inside the screen boundaries or just out of it. In such cases the perfect zoom might be something like 154 per cent. Using the Zoom slider at the bottom right of the Office application window, you can achieve these exact zoom levels.

IRFANVIEW



When it comes to image manipulation, nothing (and we do mean *nothing*) beats IrfanView. This tiny and light freeware application uses negligible system resources, is fast, and has a gazillion options to help you manipulate images. It can also do basic touchups to your images, apart from the regular resizing and Web compression that it is most popularly used for! Let's see what exactly is possible with this little wonder software. You can find the installer for IrfanView on every month's Digit CD under the Digital Tools > Essentials section.



Easy Screenshots

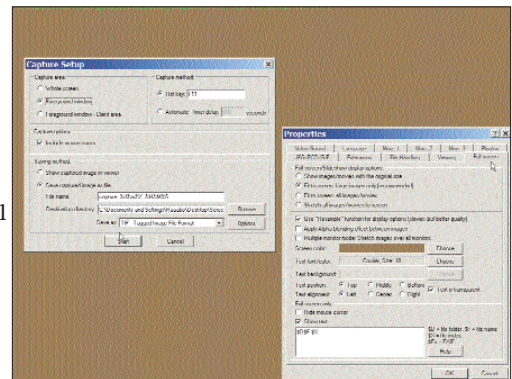
For Digit writers, taking screenshots is second nature. However, a lot of people out there need to take screenshots on a regular basis—to post content online, show an expert for help with troubleshooting, explain solutions (if they're the expert), for blog posts, etc. Most of us just press [Print Screen] and

then paste into an image editing program such as MS Paint or Adobe Photoshop. IrfanView, however, can make such a task as easy as apple pie: just start IrfanView, press [C], and you should see the Capture Setup dialog box. Here you can choose a hotkey for screen capture, where to save the captured file, and even what format to save it in. No more hassles taking screenshots!



Full-screen Control

This one's easy: just press [Enter] after you open an image. You can use the right arrow key or the spacebar to go to the next image in the directory, and the left arrow key to see the previous image. This is child's play, however. What is interesting is that if your images are rather dark, they will end up blending into the default black background that IrfanView uses. Instead of settling for this black background, you can choose another colour. Go to **Options > Properties** (or just press [P]) and then click on the Full Screen tab. Here you will see the option for Screen Color. Just click on the colour and select something from the palette that pops up.

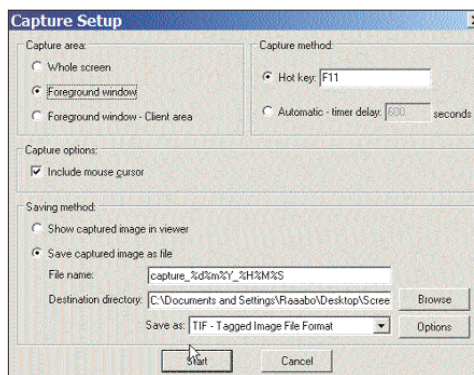


Setting the background colour for full-screen



Format Conversion

Very often we find ourselves stuck with BMP or TIFF images, which we may want to upload to the Web. Now these files are generally large, and for screen rendering (images on Web sites) no one needs anything higher in quality than JPEG. So instead of uploading a 1 MB image of your vacation to the States, do everyone in your mailing list a favour and convert it to a more manageable JPEG. All you need to do is press [S], and the "Save Picture As..." dialog box pops up. Select the directory you want to save it to, the Save Quality (compression level)—70 per cent should be fine—and even save as a



Setting up screen capture options